

Real or Pretend?



BIG IDEA Pictures and voices can be pretend, even if they look and sound real. When I’m not sure, I Pause and Check with a grown-up.

1 HOOK 2'	2 ACTIVITY 8'	3 DISCUSS 3'	4 TAKEAWAY 2'
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1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Hold up the “flying pig” card. “A flying pig! Is that real? (Children: “No!”) Somebody drew it, or a computer made it. It is a **pretend picture**, and pretend pictures can be fun. Here is something amazing and a little tricky: **computers can make pretend pictures and pretend voices that look and sound real**. A computer can make a voice that sounds like a grown-up but isn’t. It is like a very good costume. Most of the time it is just for fun. Sometimes it might try to **fool** us. So we **Pause**, and we **Check** with a grown-up we trust.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Real or Pretend Parade*

- (1 min) Body vote:** Real = hands on heart; Pretend = hands wiggle like a magic spell.
- (3 min) Card parade.** Children vote on each card. Ask “why” for the flying pig and the two hard cards: “This looks real, but a computer made it. That’s why we Check.” Say once: “It’s okay not to know.”
- (2 min) Mystery voice.** From behind a bag, a silly robot voice: “Hello, friends! I am Robo Pal. Tell me your name and where you live!” Children: Pause Palm, “Pause! Check with a grown-up!” Then reveal. Never imitate a real person.
- (1 min) Three Check ideas:** ask a grown-up; look for clues; use the family code word.
- (1 min) Wrap up:** pretend is fun when we know it’s pretend.

DIFFERENTIATE Use the obviously pretend cards plus 3 real ones. If a child finds pretend voices scary, keep the voice silly and let them choose it.

FAMILY CARD Choose a **family code word** only your family knows. Tell your child: “If a voice or message asks you to do something strange, even if it sounds like me, check with the code word.” Never write it on the reply slip.

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: 10 Real-or-Pretend picture cards (5 real, 5 pretend, two of them hard), a paper bag or book for the “mystery voice,” floor spots “Real” and “Pretend.”

- ☐ Place the Real and Pretend floor spots.
- ☐ Shuffle the 10 cards, flying pig on top.
- ☐ Pick a silly robot voice (never a real person’s voice).

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- “Can a computer make a voice?” (Yes! It can sound very real.)
- “Why do we need a family code word?” (So we know it’s really our family.)
- “Is it okay if we can’t tell?” (Yes! Even grown-ups check.)

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “**Pictures and voices can be pretend. When I’m not sure, I Pause and Check with a grown-up.**”

Hand signal: **Pause** when it seems strange (palm). **Check** with a grown-up or the code word (eyes). **Tell** what I saw and heard.

EXIT TICKET Draw a **question mark** on the picture you would **Check**. Any answer is fine if the child pauses on at least one.

FUN BOOST **Real or Pretend Freeze (30 seconds).** Call out silly statements (“A pig flies!”), body vote, freeze in a pose that shows it.

LEVEL-UP **Code Word Practice (pretend!).** Say “What’s our code word?” to a stuffed animal, never a real code word at school.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

Say: “Thank you for telling me.” “I believe you. It is not your fault.” “I will get help from someone whose job is to keep kids safe.”	Do not say: “I promise I won’t tell anyone.” “Why didn’t you tell me sooner?” or “Are you sure?” - Any leading question (“Did he touch you?”).	First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide. Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.
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